Skeptic's audit of "How marketing companies are actually marketing in the AI era"

Bottom line: The report was directionally useful, but it did not meet its own strict sourcing standard in several places. It mixed (1) platform rules, (2) vendor surveys and price pages, (3) one old lead-response study, and (4) my own operational advice and time/budget estimates. It sometimes made the combined picture sound more proven for local services than the sources allow.

This audit distinguishes **unsupported by the sources I cited**, **vendor-sourced**, and **overstated**. "Unsupported" means I did not find evidence in the cited material for that claim—not necessarily that it is false.

Claims I cannot back with the cited sources, or that need narrower wording

Report claim or implication	Audit
"Most marketing companies" are using AI in the described local-growth loop (opening paragraph).	**Unsupported as a market-wide finding.** The report cited surveys of marketers/agencies and product announcements, not a representative census of agencies serving local trades. Better: "Several platforms and agencies are adding AI to these functions; the cited evidence does not establish how prevalent this is among local-service agencies."
Being easier to reach and trust is "the durable advantage."	**Reasonable synthesis, not a measured comparative result.** No cited trial compared reach/trust against other advantages for local trades. It should have been labeled as the report's operating hypothesis.
"AI part is real, but uneven," and table's account of what agencies sell.	"Uneven" is a synthesis. The sources show product launches, agency survey intentions, and vendor offerings; they do not show a full 2026 market inventory. "Agencies are unquestionably packaging AI-search work" is too absolute: SE Ranking/Duda surveyed agencies about intent and price; it did not audit all agency offerings.

“GEO/AEO is agency shorthand … It is not a separate Google ranking product.”	The definition is useful, but **“agency shorthand” and market prevalence were not independently established**. Google’s documentation supports “no separate technical requirements for eligibility,” not that no distinct ranking systems or product behaviors exist. Say: “GEO/AEO are industry terms; Google says no special AI-only technical optimization is required for AI Overviews/AI Mode.”
The table says “accurate, indexable service information; good pages; current GBP; measurement in Search Console” are “what is actually established.”	Google documentation supports eligibility and general site guidance, not that these actions **cause local leads or AI citations**. Search Console reports visibility metrics; it does not attribute booked jobs. Replace “established” with “Google-recommended prerequisites/measurement.”
“No causal local-service evidence was found” for GEO and “published local evidence is mostly vendor case material” for AI receptionists.	These were **search findings**, not demonstrated exhaustive reviews. The defensible wording is: “I did not find independent causal local-service evidence among the sources reviewed.”
“Marketers are using AI to edit, caption, resize, transcribe, and draft.”	Wyzowl supports use of AI video tools at a high level; **it does not document that exact list of tasks or local-service adoption**. Those tasks are plausible examples, not study findings.
“A single record … makes follow-up measurable,” and “unified data is associated with faster response.”	The first is a **logical measurement statement** (a record enables recording), not a cited outcomes study. Salesforce reports a survey association, not causality and not local service results. The report then inferred fragmented systems cause generic/mistimed messages; that exact causal statement was **not established by the Salesforce survey**.
“AI reduces editing and copy overhead.”	**Plausible, but unsourced in the cited evidence.** No time-and-motion or cost comparison was cited. Treat it as a hypothesis to test against actual hours and spend.
The listed job-site video types “perform better for this market than generic AI	**Unsupported comparative-performance claims.** No local trades experiment was cited.

content," and "the owner or technician is the differentiator."	They are creative recommendations, not evidence-based rankings.
45–60 minute weekly capture, three short pieces, and 90 minutes/week.	**My invented workflow estimates.** No source established that this cadence is optimal, feasible, or sufficient. Keep only as an optional starting experiment, labeled as a guess.
"Google Search and LSAs remain the usable paid-demand tools" / "Google first."	Too broad without a market-specific comparison. Google's help page verifies LSA mechanics and eligible categories, **not that LSAs/search outperform referrals, marketplaces, Meta, or other channels** in a given trade/ZIP. Better: "They are available and directly intent-oriented; test against your local alternatives."
"For urgent local services, Google Search and LSA…"	"Urgent local services" is a sensible use case, but the source does not measure lead quality by urgency. Local Services Ads availability and billing details are sourced; comparative effectiveness is not.
"Meta is generally a demand-creation and retargeting channel" for local services.	**Unsourced generalization.** It may be a useful planning distinction, but no cited local-trades channel study establishes it. Label as a hypothesis to test, not a rule.
"Do not spread a small budget across Google, Meta, ChatGPT, SEO, and five content platforms."	**Recommendation based on dilution logic, not directly tested in the cited sources.** Retain as practical advice, not a researched result.
"The practical agency workflow is simple" and the enumeration of how agencies use AI for video.	**Not sourced to a direct observation/sample of agencies.** Wyzowl's survey establishes self-reported AI-video-tool adoption, not this workflow.
Reviews become "the proof layer"; review details/photos/videos are what consumers look at; AI summaries surface patterns.	The BrightLocal survey supports self-reported review/source checking and preferences. "Proof layer," "summaries surface patterns," and impacts on conversion are interpretive. BrightLocal is also a local-marketing vendor survey, not transaction or clickstream data.
"A good contract leaves the ad account, tracking number, landing page, CRM data, and creative accessible to the business."	Strong buyer-protection advice, but **not a factual research finding** in the cited sources. Keep as recommendation.

“A hybrid can work if the business can verify the outcome in its own CRM.”	**Conditional business judgment, not an observed result** from the cited sources. No causal proof supplied.
“A one-person local operator does not need enterprise tooling … one shared lead record … can be simpler—and more reliable—than a large company’s stack.”	“Does not need a data warehouse” is likely sound for this use case, but the comparative “more reliable” claim is **unsupported**. Salesforce’s survey is not evidence that small firms outperform enterprises. Better: “A small firm can begin without a data warehouse; whether simpler is more reliable depends on execution.”
“AI review summaries make authentic detail more valuable.”	Plausible implication from a BrightLocal vendor survey that respondents check sources; **not a measured effect on rankings, selection, or sales**.
“AI search can reduce outbound clicks” inferred from Pew.	Pew measured Google searches and clicks in March 2025; this supports fewer link clicks in observed AI-summary visits, but not whether users later called, searched a brand, used Maps, or converted. The report did flag this limitation, but its explanation of post-summary behavior was speculation.
“ChatGPT ads … watchlist or small experiment, not shift a working budget.”	The new-ad-product status and lack of local-service evidence are supportable from the cited OpenAI announcement. The budget recommendation is **my risk-management judgment**, not a measured allocation rule.
“One review request per completed job” / all eligible customers, no screening.	The compliance direction is sound and supported by FTC/Google policies; **the report did not source an optimal request timing/frequency or prove that universal requests improve rating or ranking**.
“One immediate confirmation, one human call/message, and a small number of useful follow-ups.”	**Unsourced workflow advice.** It is not an evidence-based universal sequence. Consent, customer preference, channel, service type, and state rules matter.

First five moves: their order, price budgets, and setup/weekly/monthly time estimates.	**These were recommendations, not study-derived rankings.** The first four are mostly reasonable low-cost actions, but all time estimates (1–5 hours, 10 minutes/day, 30 minutes/month, etc.) were my guesses. The $1,000–$1,500 ad test was an illustrative budget, not a validated minimum sample size.
Calling the list “the first five moves” in a universal order.	**Overconfident.** A business with no capacity, poor margins, or a seasonal business may rationally prioritize operations, referrals, or retention before ads. Order should depend on the business’s bottleneck.
“Three most overhyped” claims are definitively the three most overhyped in 2026.	**Not established by a systematic survey of claims/advertising.** They are three examples the cited evidence challenges, not a ranked top-three list.
“AI is changing the operating system of local marketing more than creating a reliable new lead source.”	Concise and likely directionally right, but **not directly measured by the sources**. It should be called a synthesis, not a proven industry-wide finding.

Every number in the report that came from a vendor or platform

These figures should not be presented as independent truth. Some are prices (real listed prices, but still seller-controlled and subject to plan/region/date); others are survey responses, benchmarks, or platform-reported performance.

Figure(s)	Origin and what it actually represents
94%, 61%, $937/mo; 53%, 64%, 85%, 93%	SE Ranking/Duda agency-pricing survey: dataset of 170 agency responses plus 90 agency-catalog price entries (260 total); 94% served small/local businesses; 61% planned AI optimization; 43% planned to fold it in and 18% planned it as an add-on; $937 average among agencies with finalized/intended pricing. The page itself cautions the sample may not be statistically significant. These show respondent plans and prices, not service adoption market share or ROI.

45%, 455 people, 31%, 23%, 88%, 97%, 42%	BrightLocal 2026 Local Consumer Review Survey: 1,002 U.S. adults via SurveyMonkey; the AI-user subset was 455. The 45% is reported AI use for local recommendations; 31% ChatGPT and 23% Google AI Mode; 88% check legitimacy/source (reported as 51% legitimacy and 37% source); 97% sometimes double-check recommendations against real reviews; 42% always check reviews on native review platforms. Vendor survey, self-report, not observed transactions.
28% unanswered calls	CallRail’ s beta-participant comparison, not a representative industry-wide call census.
$29/month, 30 conversations, $0.79 overage	Jobber vendor price/capability page for AI Receptionist, subject to plan/eligibility and current terms. Not ROI evidence.
$95/month, 50 included calls, $1 overage; $50–$55/month tracking	CallRail vendor pricing. The report said “roughly $145–$150” by adding the components; the page/finding summary gave a range, so the combination is an arithmetic estimate, and the exact starting tracking fee/requirements should be reconfirmed before purchase. Not a total-cost guarantee.
$300/month for 30 calls	Smith.ai vendor price page; a listed plan, not proof of value or a like-for-like service comparison.
$7.85 CPC, $90.92 CPL; 16,446 campaigns	WordStream/LocaliQ benchmark from its Google Ads dataset. It is a vendor benchmark; “Home & Home Improvement” is a broad category, not pest-control, plumbing, HVAC, roofing, or lawn-care local-specific median. The report correctly labeled it vendor benchmark, but using it to estimate a local test’ s lead count remains only rough arithmetic.
$500–$2,500/mo PPC management; $1,000–$5,000+ ad spend; $500–$1,500/mo lower-tier management; $25–$150+ exclusive leads	Home-service agencies/marketing sellers’ public pricing/guides (Hook Agency, ClicksGeek). **[vendor claim]** Their own market experience/prices, with no independent representative pricing sample or documented service-level comparability. The $25–$150+ exclusive-lead range is especially weak as a general market estimate.

$1,557/mo local SEO; $501–$1,000 common retainer; 78.2% retainers	Ahrefs survey of SEO providers. Vendor-produced provider survey; “local SEO” scope differs by provider and is not a local-business customer invoice census.
$100–$149/hour and most projects under $10,000	Clutch’s listed agency/review data. Vendor marketplace aggregation, not a specific short-form video production quote. The report’s conclusion “professional producer is not cheap” was evaluative.
59%, 69%, 63%, 82%; 266 respondents	Wyzowl 2026 survey of 266 marketing professionals/consumers. Vendor survey; 82% “good ROI” is self-report and cross-industry, not audited causal ROI.
69%, 42%; 4,450 marketers	Salesforce 2026 marketer survey. Vendor-produced, worldwide marketing decision-maker survey: 69% reported difficulty responding promptly; the 42% is a relative likelihood association among those satisfied with unified data. Not a causal increase, and not local service owners.
Twilio survey figures	Twilio vendor survey (7,640 consumers and 637 business leaders in 18 countries, per source notes). The report made no exact percentage claim from it, but used it to support a broad “gap” statement; self-reported, global, cross-industry, noncausal.
Up to 5% conversions; $4.52 revenue per $1; 22% lift	Meta’s internal ad-product reporting/earnings claims. Not independently audited in the cited source and not specific to local trades. The report included up to 5% and $4.52 but omitted the associated 22% comparison and did not describe the test conditions; that presentation risks making the figure sound more transferable than it is.
240 million policy-violating reviews	Google’s own count of reviews it blocked/removed in 2024, published April 2025. Platform enforcement figure; not an independent audit and not evidence of local ranking effect.
2026: October 5 OpenAI ad announcement and initial U.S. test	OpenAI’s own product announcement; its early partner results are seller/partner-

	reported and not local-service results. Product status is time-sensitive.
Microsoft Copilot ad pilots and relevance/click-through claims	Microsoft’ s product announcement and internal figures; not an independent performance result for local businesses.

Other numbers: sourced, but not vendor-independent or still limited

- **Pew: 68,879 searches, 900 U.S. adults; 8% versus 15% link clicks; 1% click on AI-summary source links.** This is independent behavioral evidence, but limited to Google searches observed in March 2025. It is not a local-services or downstream conversion study. The original report’ s “AI summary pages can reduce outbound clicks” is defensible if narrowed to this observation; its speculation that consumers subsequently verify firms in Maps/reviews was not measured by Pew.
- **Old MIT/InsideSales study: 3 years, 6 companies, >15,000 web leads, >100,000 call attempts; 5-min versus 30-min “100x contact / 21x qualification.”** The source is the 2007 study presented by MIT professor James Oldroyd and InsideSales CEO Dave Elkington, with data from InsideSales.com systems. It explicitly says it did **not** measure close ratios. “100x” and “21x” are odds/rates as described in this dated vendor-supported study, not the effect of an AI receptionist; broad use outside those web leads is not established. The earlier report called it “vendor-supported,” but should have made the commercial data source more prominent.
- **Google AI Search Console report dates and functionality.** These are Google platform announcements, not external performance research. They document reporting availability, not whether GEO services yield sales. Any exact rollout timing is volatile and should be rechecked.
- **Google says GBP is free; Bing Places is free.** These are platform terms/announcements and can change. “$0 platform fee” does not include labor, site changes, optional tools, verification requirements, or agency fees.
- **Google LSA availability and pay-per-lead description.** This is official Google product guidance. Availability varies by category and market; “pay for related leads” is not a published universal cost per booked job. The report’ s list of categories was based on Google’ s current eligibility page, not a finding that each category gets LSA in every ZIP.
- **FCC AI voice ruling (2024) and FTC review rule (effective Oct. 21, 2024).** These are legal/regulatory sources rather than vendor claims. The report’ s plain-language

summary is useful but not legal advice; compliance depends on call/text purpose, consent, technology, jurisdiction, and workflow.

Price ranges and advice that were not market-wide facts

The exact reported vendor prices are traceable to price pages, but the following figures were **my estimates**, not source findings:

- **$0 manual missed-call text**: only if the existing carrier/phone plan supports it at no incremental cost; the report should not imply this is universally free.
- **$145–$150 CallRail bundle**: arithmetic combining published starting prices, subject to plan details and usage; not a verified all-in quote.
- **$1,000–$1,500 ad test and 11–16.5 lead arithmetic**: the division uses vendor-benchmark $90.92 CPL. It is not a recommended statistically powered test, forecast, or guaranteed number of leads. A real budget needs local keyword/LSA quotes, margin, close rate, capacity, and a chosen test duration.
- **All time figures**: 1–5 hours setup, 10 minutes/day, 15 minutes/week, 30 minutes/month, 30–60 minutes/week, 45–60 minute filming block, three clips, 90 minutes/week, and one hour review setup. These were unaudited planning guesses.
- **“One service, one service area”**: a simplification to control a test, not a universal campaign design.
- **$0 cost for review asks/local facts**: only software/platform cost assuming existing equipment and access. Labor and any website, call tracking, CRM, or agency work can cost money.
- **“Most agencies” / “commonly” agency fee estimates**: while the report cited actual published seller prices and provider surveys, it did not have a representative 2026 census of agency contracts. Treat fee bands as examples from sources, not universal market-clearing prices.

What I overstated most

1. **I let availability/eligibility sound like effectiveness.** Google’s docs prove that AI Overview ads and LSAs exist and how they work—not that they outperform alternatives for local trades.
2. **I let survey adoption or intent sound like business impact.** Wyzowl, BrightLocal, Salesforce, Twilio, and SE Ranking/Duda are useful directional surveys but mostly self-reported, vendor-produced, and not studies of booked jobs or profit.

3. **I let operational advice sound like researched findings.** The weekly video cadence, the five-move order, CRM field list, callback sequence, and time estimates were my recommendations. I should have labeled each as a practical hypothesis to test.
4. **I overstated how much the report could answer "how companies are actually marketing."** Sources showed tools, vendor examples, and what surveyed agencies say they plan to sell; they did not establish what a representative share of local-service companies or agencies actually do in 2026.
5. **I used prices as if they were comparable.** A listed AI receptionist conversation, tracked phone call, SEO retainer, video agency hour, PPC management fee, and exclusive lead are different units and scopes. Prices are examples, not an apples-to-apples market table.
6. **I called three claims "the most overhyped."** I had evidence against those claims, not a systematic ranking. They should be "three claims the cited evidence does not support."

Corrected top five takeaways, with confidence

Confidence refers to confidence in the narrowly worded takeaway, not certainty about the revenue outcome for your particular business.

#	Corrected takeaway	Confidence	What the evidence supports—and does not
1	**Do not buy a special GEO trick before fixing accurate local information and basic site eligibility.** Google says no special AI-only schema/file is required for AI Overviews/AI Mode; it does not promise this foundation will get you cited or generate leads.	**High** for Google's documented technical guidance; **low–moderate** for impact on local revenue	Google Search Central is direct evidence of its requirements. There is no causal local-service uplift in the sources reviewed.
2	**Treat unanswered inbound leads as an operational leak worth measuring; do not assume AI is the**	**Moderate** that faster response deserves testing; **low** on expected uplift and AI-specific ROI	One old, vendor-supported web-lead study supports a steep response-time association. It did not

	answer. Track response time, contact, booked estimates, and sold jobs before and after a human callback or AI overflow pilot.		measure close ratios or AI and is not a modern trades trial.
3	**Use ads where local intent and measurement are available, but decide by your own booked-job economics.** Google Search and LSA are usable products; neither source nor benchmark proves which wins in your market. Start narrowly only if capacity, margin, and tracking are ready.	**High** that products/pricing models exist; **low–moderate** on channel ranking and expected results	Official Google product guidance plus vendor benchmark data; broad CPL benchmark is not a local trade forecast.
4	**AI can lower content-production friction, but local proof is the content strategy.** Use real job footage and human review as an experiment; judge by qualified inquiries and sales, not views or number of AI posts.	**Moderate** that marketers report using AI-video tools; **low** that the recommended formats outperform for local service businesses	Wyzowl is an adoption/self-reported ROI survey. No cited local-service randomized or causal content test. The suggested cadence is optional, unsourced trial design.
5	**A simple lead record plus consent-aware follow-up is enough to start.** Capture source, response, outcome, and next action in the CRM you already use; buy extra software only to solve a measured gap.	**High** that a record permits measurement; **moderate** that simple is adequate for many small operators; **low** that this alone improves conversion	Salesforce/Twilio provide broad vendor-survey context, not causality for trades. The six-field schema is a practical recommendation, not a validated optimum.

If reducing it to a one-person action list

I would now present the actions as **low-risk experiments, not a proven ranking**:

1. For two weeks, log every inbound call/form, response time, contact, booking, and sale. Cost: typically no new software if you already have a phone/CRM; time estimate is your own choice, not a published norm.
2. Fix Google Business Profile and Bing Places facts and make sure the site is accessible/indexable. Their platform listings are currently free; labor is not.
3. Create a neutral, compliant review-request process for completed jobs; do not condition it on positive sentiment.
4. If missed calls are common, compare a manual callback process with a low-cost answering pilot using real call transcripts and booked-job outcomes; do not buy based on an ROI promise.
5. Only then run one paid channel test sized to your local auction, gross margin, closing rate, and capacity. Treat vendor CPL figures as a starting question, not a forecast.

Sources explicitly checked for this audit

- Google Search Central: AI features and your website
- Google Search Central: using generative AI content
- SE Ranking/Duda agency pricing survey
- BrightLocal 2026 AI/local recommendation survey
- Pew Research Center analysis of Google AI summaries and clicks
- MIT/InsideSales lead-response study PDF
- HBR, “The Short Life of Online Sales Leads”
- Hook Agency 2026 home-service marketing-cost guide
- WordStream/LocaliQ Google Ads benchmarks
- FTC reviews rule Q&A
- Salesforce State of Marketing 2026